Explanatory document · Interactive toolkit companion

ESC Volunteer Hostel Toolkit

How the toolkit works, the nine phases, the six city contexts, the financial model and every data point it uses.



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Interactive application:
https://claude.ai/artifact/1BdGZ9pA3zoWmep6kd4jiB

Prototype estimates for academic purposes. Not financial or legal advice. Verify with national authorities.

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1. About this document

This document accompanies the interactive ESC Volunteer Hostel Toolkit. It explains what the toolkit is, how the web application works, and sets out every piece of data the application uses, with its source and its verification status. It lets a reader check the toolkit without opening the application, and it records the reasoning behind each figure.

The toolkit is a method artefact in the design-science sense (Hevner et al., 2004): a step-by-step framework enabling an organisation in any EU Programme Country to found, accredit, finance, staff, launch and sustain a volunteer-based social-enterprise hostel through the European Solidarity Corps (ESC). Porto, Portugal, is the primary verified case. Lyon, Strasbourg, Berlin, Barcelona and Rome are orientation points that direct the user to the right national institutions without the same depth of verification.

1.1 Status labels

Every data point in the toolkit and in this document carries one of the following labels.

Label	Meaning	What the user should do
[Verified]	Confirmed against a named primary source (legislation, official portal, official guide).	Use, but reconfirm for the current year before committing money.
[Estimate]	Market estimate or orientation figure (listings, price surveys, prototype assumption).	Replace with live local data before any financial planning.
[Verify locally]	Rule or figure that depends on national or local authorities, or on the current call year.	Confirm with the national ESC agency or local authority.
[Design choice]	Deliberate design choice of the toolkit (scale, number of volunteers).	Can be changed; the calculator shows the effect.
[Calculated]	Derived by formula from other figures.	Recalculates automatically in the application.

1.2 Who can use the toolkit

Suitable	Not suitable
Any EU Programme Country	Non-EU jurisdictions (different ESC rules)
Any legal person able to form a non-profit association	Commercial companies (legal form incompatible)
Any city with basic, year-round tourism demand	Strongly seasonal destinations (revenue concentration risk)
Scale of about 15–30 beds	Scale above ~30 beds (regulatory thresholds differ)
Founding team of 3+ members (7 in Germany and Alsace-Moselle)	Solo founders (an association needs several members)

2. How the interactive application works

The application is a single self-contained web page published at https://claude.ai/artifact/1BdGZ9pA3zoWmep6kd4jiB. It needs no installation or account to view once shared, and it works on desktop and mobile in light or dark mode.

2.1 Structure

Part	What it shows	How the user interacts
City selector (top bar)	Porto (verified) and five orientation cities.	One click changes every section: phase panels, city profile, calculator presets and national links.
Nine phases	A route timeline of the nine phases with a red line after Phase 4 (no lease before Quality Label). Each phase lists steps, forms and portals, applicable rules, and a city-specific panel.	Click a station or a phase row to expand it.
City profile	Ten data cards per city: agency, legal form, tourist registration, insurance, minimum wage, tourist tax, rent, dorm price, regulatory alert, precedent.	Read-only; each card carries its status label.
Financial model — layer 1	Pre-filled estimate for the selected city: four headline figures; an operating account for Years 1–3 plus a stress test without A1; pocket money shown as a pass-through.	Read-only; changes with the city.
Financial model — layer 2	Editable calculator: monthly and annual net, break-even with and without A1, an occupancy bar, an ESC account comparing A1 with volunteer-related costs, and a travel sensitivity test.	Edit any input; 'Reset' restores the city preset.
Legal reference & links	Eight rules with source and practical consequence; EU-level portals and national links.	Links open the official sites.
About	Scope, audience, disclaimer, author.	Read-only.

2.2 Calculation logic

The calculator uses the same formulas as the Excel model (ESC_Hostel_Finance_EYVAZLI.xlsx). All figures are monthly, with a 30-day month.

Quantity	Formula
Dorm revenue	dorm beds × dorm price × 30 × occupancy
Private room revenue	private rooms × private price × 30 × occupancy
ESC organisational support	volunteers × A1 (€/day, host country) × 30
Pocket money (pass-through)	volunteers × A3 (€/day) × 30 — shown as equal income and expense
Operating revenue	dorm revenue + private revenue + A1 + activities income
Volunteer meals / transport	volunteers × €225 / volunteers × €40
Operating costs	rent + utilities + internet/PMS + insurance + meals + local transport + workshops + manager + paid housekeeping + cleaning supplies + marketing + contingency

Quantity	Formula
Net monthly result	operating revenue − operating costs; annual = monthly × 12
Maximum bed revenue	(dorm beds × dorm price + private rooms × private price) × 30
Break-even with A1	(operating costs − A1) ÷ maximum bed revenue
Break-even without A1	operating costs ÷ maximum bed revenue
Volunteer-related costs (ESC account)	20% × (rent + utilities) + meals + transport + workshops + 50% × manager
Travel (pass-through)	journeys per year × band unit cost, compared with ticket estimates

Break-even occupancy counts bed revenue only; activities income is excluded to stay conservative. The occupancy bar tells the user which of four situations applies: covers costs without the grant; breaks even only thanks to the grant; loses money even with the grant; or cannot break even without the grant even at 100%. A warning appears above six volunteers, since each needs a separate room and more mentoring capacity.

2.3 Editable inputs

Main: occupancy (slider), number of volunteers, A1 rate, dorm price, private price, rent, activities income. Advanced: beds, manager, paid housekeeping, meals, local transport, every other cost line, A3. ESC account and travel: volunteer share of rent, manager time on volunteer support, placement length, typical and far travel bands, green travel, number of far-band volunteers, ticket estimates.

3. The nine phases

The phases must run in sequence. Several have hard dependencies; breaking them causes the project to fail. Total indicative duration from concept to opening is roughly 7–10 months, because Phases 5–6 run partly in parallel with the Quality Label review.

Critical sequencing rule

Do not sign the property lease before the Quality Label is approved (end of Phase 4). Signing earlier means paying rent without the right to host volunteers. The property search may start during Phase 4; only the signature waits.

#	Phase	Duration	Output
1	Define concept and mission	1–2 weeks	Mission document; founding team committed
2	Register the non-profit association	2–6 weeks	Registration certificate; legal entity; bank account
3	Obtain the Organisation ID (OID)	1–3 days	OID confirmed; organisation visible on EU portals
4	Apply for the ESC Quality Label	8–12 weeks	Quality Label approved; access to the ESC portal
5	Design volunteer learning roles	1–2 weeks	Four role descriptions linked to Youthpass key competences
6	Find and prepare the space	4–8 weeks	Property; fire certificate; insurance; tourist registration
7	Recruit ESC volunteers	4–6 weeks	Volunteers selected; agreements signed; travel arranged
8	Put the six support conditions in place	2–4 weeks	All six conditions documented before day 1
9	Launch: induction and soft opening	2 weeks	Volunteers integrated; hostel open; reviews building

Phase 1 — Define concept and mission

Duration: 1–2 weeks **Output:** Mission document; founding team committed

Steps

1. Write a one-page mission statement aligned to ESC values: solidarity, intercultural dialogue, active citizenship.
2. Name the social problem the hostel addresses.
3. Choose the target neighbourhood and scale (model: 20 beds — 16 dorm, 4 private).
4. Commit a founding team of at least three people.

Rules that apply

- Mission reflects the programme objectives in Reg. 2021/888, Art. 3.

Phase 2 — Register the non-profit association

Duration: 2–6 weeks **Output:** Registration certificate; legal entity; bank account

Steps

1. Draft statutes with a mission clause naming ESC values explicitly.
2. State that surplus is reinvested in the social purpose.
3. Register with the national non-profit authority.
4. Open a bank account in the association's name.

Forms and portals

- Statutes
- Founding members' IDs
- Notary or witness signatures where required

Rules that apply

- Non-profit legal form only.

Phase 3 — Obtain the Organisation ID (OID)

Duration: 1–3 days **Output:** OID confirmed; organisation visible on EU portals

Steps

1. Create an EU Login account (webgate.ec.europa.eu/cas).
2. Open the Erasmus+ and ESC organisation registration system.
3. Register the association with the Phase 2 certificate.
4. Record the OID: letter E followed by 8 digits.

Forms and portals

- EU Login
- Organisation registration system (webgate.ec.europa.eu/erasmus-esc)

Rules that apply

- Identical procedure in every Programme Country.

Phase 4 — Apply for the ESC Quality Label

Duration: 8–12 weeks **Output:** Quality Label approved; access to the ESC portal

Steps

1. Download the sample Quality Label form (ESC50) and read the Activities section first.
2. Complete the four areas: organisational capacity, volunteer support quality, activity learning design, compliance.
3. In every activity, state the competency first and the task second — where most applications fail.
4. Call the national agency before submitting.
5. Submit online with EU Login; applications are accepted on a continuous basis.

Forms and portals

- Quality Label page (youth.europa.eu/solidarity/organisations/quality-label_en)
- Calls for proposals and forms

Rules that apply

- The Quality Label is non-budgetary. Only lead organisations can apply for Volunteering Project grants, and the lead label requires at least one year of legal establishment. In Year 1, grant income reaches the hostel through a partner lead organisation's project.

Phase 5 — Design volunteer learning roles

Duration: 1–2 weeks **Output:** Four role descriptions linked to Youthpass key competences

Steps

1. Write four roles with the mandatory formula (Section 4).
2. Link every activity to at least one Youthpass key competence.
3. Plan 30–38 hours a week with two consecutive days off.
4. Check no role replaces a paid job.

Forms and portals

- Youthpass key competences (youthpass.eu)

Rules that apply

- No job substitution: Reg. 2021/888, Art. 7 and the Quality Label principles — volunteers complement paid staff, never replace them or undercut their pay.
- Avoid routine tasks with low learning impact; cleaning, laundry and unsupervised shifts are paid-staff work.
- Hours and rest: ESC Guide.

Phase 6 — Find and prepare the space

Duration: 4–8 weeks **Output:** Property; fire certificate; insurance; tourist registration

Steps

1. Check building and zoning rules before any viewing.
2. 150–200 m² with separate volunteer rooms not shared with guests.
3. Fire-safety certificate; civil-liability insurance at the national minimum.
4. Tourist accommodation registration.
5. In residential buildings, obtain owners' approval in writing before signing.
6. Sign the lease only after Quality Label approval.

Rules that apply

- Suitable, separate volunteer accommodation is a host obligation (ESC Guide).

Phase 7 — Recruit ESC volunteers

Duration: 4–6 weeks **Output:** Volunteers selected; agreements signed; travel arranged

Steps

1. Publish placements on the ESC portal after Quality Label approval.
2. Eligibility: 18–30 at the start, registered on the ESC portal, no qualifications required.
3. Select with CV, motivation letter and video call; filter on values, not hospitality skills.
4. Keep two backup candidates.
5. Sign the volunteering agreement with each volunteer.

Forms and portals

- European Youth Portal (youth.europa.eu/solidarity)

Rules that apply

- Age 18–30 at start (Reg. 2021/888).
- Travel is a unit cost per participant by distance band (€28–€1,735), a pass-through to the volunteer.
- Projects of four volunteers or fewer may include one volunteer from a non-associated third country above the 25% limit.

Phase 8 — Put the six support conditions in place

Duration: 2–4 weeks **Output:** All six conditions documented before day 1

Steps

1. Separate furnished accommodation, fully paid by the association.
2. Healthy meals or a food allowance, including holidays — paid by the host from A1 (no separate EU food allowance).
3. Local transport available (e.g. monthly pass).
4. Pocket money paid weekly or monthly (A3; Portugal €6/day).
5. Named mentor, at least 20 hours a month, documented.
6. Online Language Support (OLS) activated on day 1.
7. On-arrival training date confirmed with the national agency.
8. Youthpass opened on day 1.

Forms and portals

- OLS (erasmusplusols.eu — may redirect to the EU Academy)
- Youthpass (youthpass.eu)

Rules that apply

- Host tasks (ESC Guide 2026): accommodation, healthy meals or food allowance, local transport, the due allowance weekly or monthly, a mentor, task-related support.

Phase 9 — Launch: induction and soft opening

Duration: 2 weeks **Output:** Volunteers integrated; hostel open; reviews building

Steps

1. Day 1: welcome meal, room set-up, city orientation.
2. Day 2: role briefing (learning goals first), shadow shift.
3. Day 3: first supervised session, OLS account.
4. Day 4: language lesson, neighbourhood exploration.
5. Day 5: 30-day goals with mentor, Youthpass log opened.
6. Soft opening at 30–40% capacity for at least two weeks; the first 20 reviews set platform ranking for months.

Rules that apply

- Tourist-tax collection starts with the first guest where the city charges one.

After launch

Rhythm	Activities
Daily	Supervised learning sessions; reply to reviews within 24 hours.
Weekly	Monday team meeting; Wednesday community dinner.
Monthly	Report to the national agency; financial reconciliation; mentoring sessions; one skill workshop; Youthpass log updates; tourist-tax remittance where applicable.
Year 1	Social Impact Report (December); Quality Label follow-up.
Year 2	Green Key certification application (January–March).

Rhythm	Activities
Years 2–3	Apply for the lead-organisation Quality Label with the national agency.

4. Volunteer learning roles

Every activity description follows one formula, because the ESC measures success by the volunteer's competency development, not by tasks performed (Reg. 2021/888, Art. 7).

Mandatory formula

The volunteer develops [competency] through [activity]. The expected outcome is [capability measurable on Youthpass].

Never: “The volunteer will work at the reception desk.”
Always: “The volunteer develops intercultural communication and hospitality management competencies through supervised guest reception at the front desk, with the expected outcome of demonstrating B2-level professional communication in English and the target language by Month 6.”

Role	Competencies developed	Activities	Weekly hours	Youthpass competences
1. Hospitality and welcome learner	Intercultural communication, hospitality management, digital reservation systems, customer support, tourism information, language	Supervised reception (3h/day), booking enquiries, local tourism advice, review monitoring, social-media customer interaction	20–22h activities; 4–6h OLS; 2h mentoring; 4–6h reflection & Youthpass	Multilingual; personal, social & learning to learn; cultural awareness & expression
2. Community life and cultural learner	Event design and facilitation, intercultural dialogue, group leadership, project coordination, community management	Weekly community events, communal meals, cultural workshops, local partnerships, excursions	18–20h activities; 4–6h OLS; 2h mentoring; 6–8h planning & documentation	Personal, social & learning to learn; cultural awareness; citizenship
3. Sustainability and eco-management learner	Environmental monitoring, circular economy, sustainable procurement, data recording, energy/water management	5-stream waste sorting, monthly energy & water tracking, local suppliers, guest eco-orientation, Green Key preparation	20–22h activities; 4–6h OLS; 2h mentoring; 4h reporting	Mathematics, science & technology; learning to learn; citizenship
4. Digital communications and brand learner	Social media strategy, content creation, copywriting, online reputation, institutional communication	Hostel channels, photo & copy, review replies, annual Social Impact Report, listing management	20–22h activities; 4–6h OLS; 2h mentoring; 4h strategy & analytics	Digital; cultural awareness & expression; learning to learn

Hours stay within 30–38 per week with two consecutive days off (ESC Guide). Volunteers must never cover a paid post.

Staffing model: no job substitution

Paid staff run the hostel: a part-time manager (operations, supervision, mentoring) and paid housekeeping (cleaning, laundry, linen); out-of-hours arrivals use self check-in. Volunteers work alongside staff in the four learning roles, never cover a shift alone and never replace a paid post. In the thesis, describe them as learners in supervised activities — never as the hostel's operational workforce. The Guide requires that volunteers complement paid staff and do not replace them or undercut their pay and conditions.

5. The six city contexts

Each city tab in the application shows what the generic step looks like in that national context. Porto is verified against primary sources; the other five cities give institutional entry points and must be verified locally.

Porto, Portugal

Status	**[Verified]** Primary verified case
National ESC agency	Agência Nacional Erasmus+ Juventude/Desporto e Corpo Europeu de Solidariedade (with IPDJ)
Non-profit legal form	Associação — Código Civil Arts. 167–184 — RNPC registration (rnpc.mj.pt)
Tourist registration	Alojamento Local (AL) via SEUP / Balcão do Empreendedor — DL 128/2014 as amended by DL 76/2024
Key regulatory alert	Condominium assembly approval (written ata) required for hostels in residential buildings (DL 76/2024). Allow 2–4 months.
Civil liability insurance	€75,000 minimum per claim (Portaria 248/2021); ≈ €1,560/year
Minimum wage / manager	€920/month gross (DL 139/2025, from 1 Jan 2026); manager modelled at €760/month
Tourist tax	€2/person/night, max 7 nights, guests 13+, monthly remittance to Câmara Municipal
Rent 150–200 m²	€2,800–3,500/month **[Estimate]**
Dorm market price	€20–28/bed/night **[Estimate]**
Property listings	Idealista.pt, Imovirtual.pt
Volunteer language (OLS)	Portuguese
ESC precedent	Associação Spin — OID E10339100 — hostel hosting ESC volunteers since 2014 (a-spin.pt)

Lyon, France

Status	**[Estimate]** Orientation point
National ESC agency	Agence Erasmus+ France Jeunesse & Sport (erasmusplus-jeunesse.fr); regional contact via DRAJES
Non-profit legal form	Association loi 1901 — déclaration at the préfecture (service-public.fr)
Tourist registration	Hébergement touristique — declaration to the Mairie + taxe de séjour registration; likely ERP fire-safety classification
Key regulatory alert	Règlement Sanitaire Départemental governs accommodation standards; check ERP fire-safety classification with the Mairie.
Civil liability insurance	No figure — verify with Mairie and insurer
Minimum wage / manager	SMIC 2026 ≈ €1,801.80/month gross; 20h/week modelled at €900 (gross share only)
Tourist tax	Taxe de séjour ≈ €1.50–3.50/night depending on category
Rent 150–200 m²	€2,200–3,000/month **[Estimate]**
Dorm market price	€18–25/bed/night **[Estimate]**
Property listings	SeLoger, Leboncoin
Volunteer language (OLS)	French
ESC precedent	Search the European Youth Portal organisation map for French ESC hosts in hospitality

Strasbourg, France

Status	**[Estimate]** Orientation point
National ESC agency	Agence Erasmus+ France Jeunesse & Sport; Grand Est regional contact via DRAJES
Non-profit legal form	Association under Alsace-Moselle local law (Code civil local, Arts. 21–79) — registered at the Tribunal judiciaire; 7 founding members
Tourist registration	Hébergement touristique — declaration to the Mairie de Strasbourg + taxe de séjour; check ERP classification
Key regulatory alert	Alsace-Moselle does not apply the 1901 law: court registration under local law with at least 7 founders.
Civil liability insurance	No figure — verify with Mairie and insurer
Minimum wage / manager	SMIC 2026 ≈ €1,801.80/month gross; 20h/week modelled at €900 (gross share only)
Tourist tax	Taxe de séjour at category rate — verify with the Mairie
Rent 150–200 m²	€1,800–2,500/month **[Estimate]**
Dorm market price	€16–22/bed/night **[Estimate]**
Property listings	SeLoger, Leboncoin
Volunteer language (OLS)	French or German
ESC precedent	Search the European Youth Portal organisation map for Grand Est ESC hosts

Berlin, Germany

Status	**[Estimate]** Orientation point
National ESC agency	JUGEND für Europa (jugendfuereuropa.de)
Non-profit legal form	Eingetragener Verein (e.V.) — BGB §§ 21–79 — Vereinsregister at the local Amtsgericht; 7 founding members
Tourist registration	Beherbergungsstätte — Gewerbeamt registration, Ordnungsamt and building-use checks; rules vary by Bundesland
Key regulatory alert	Each Bundesland sets its own accommodation rules; confirm zoning and building-use permission with the Bezirksamt before signing.
Civil liability insurance	No figure — verify with Gewerbeamt and insurer
Minimum wage / manager	≈ €12.82/hour (2026); 20h/week modelled at €1,109 (gross only)
Tourist tax	Übernachtungsteuer charged as a percentage of the room price — verify current rate with the Senat
Rent 150–200 m²	€2,500–3,500/month **[Estimate]**
Dorm market price	€20–28/bed/night **[Estimate]**
Property listings	Immowelt, ImmobilienScout24
Volunteer language (OLS)	German
ESC precedent	Search the European Youth Portal organisation map for German ESC hosts in hospitality

Barcelona, Spain

Status	**[Estimate]** Orientation point
National ESC agency	INJUVE — Instituto de la Juventud (injuve.es)
Non-profit legal form	Asociación sin ánimo de lucro — in Catalonia Llei 4/2008 (Codi civil, llibre III) — Registre d'Entitats Jurídiques
Tourist registration	Establiment d'allotjament turístic (alberg) — Generalitat de Catalunya + Ajuntament urban plan (PEUAT)
Key regulatory alert	Barcelona's PEUAT restricts new tourist accommodation across much of the city; check the zone allows new beds before any viewing.
Civil liability insurance	No figure — verify with the Generalitat and insurer
Minimum wage / manager	SMI 2026 ≈ €1,184/month gross (14 payments); 20h/week modelled at €593 (gross share only)
Tourist tax	Catalan tourist tax + Barcelona surcharge, up to ≈ €4/person/night — verify
Rent 150–200 m²	€2,800–3,800/month **[Estimate]**
Dorm market price	€18–26/bed/night **[Estimate]**
Property listings	Idealista.com, Fotocasa
Volunteer language (OLS)	Spanish or Catalan
ESC precedent	Search the European Youth Portal organisation map for Spanish ESC hosts in hospitality

Rome, Italy

Status	**[Estimate]** Orientation point
National ESC agency	Agenzia Italiana per la Gioventù (formerly Agenzia Nazionale per i Giovani)
Non-profit legal form	APS — Codice del Terzo Settore (D.Lgs. 117/2017) — RUNTS registration
Tourist registration	Struttura ricettiva extralberghiera (ostello) — SCIA via the Comune's SUAP; Regione Lazio rules
Key regulatory alert	Accommodation rules are regional and change often; confirm current Regione Lazio ostello requirements with the SUAP.
Civil liability insurance	No figure — verify with the Comune and insurer
Minimum wage / manager	No statutory minimum wage (CCNL Turismo); manager modelled at €900 as a placeholder
Tourist tax	Contributo di soggiorno ≈ €6/person/night (2024 rate) — verify
Rent 150–200 m²	€2,200–3,200/month **[Estimate]**
Dorm market price	€18–26/bed/night **[Estimate]**
Property listings	Immobiliare.it, Idealista.it
Volunteer language (OLS)	Italian
ESC precedent	Search the European Youth Portal organisation map for Italian ESC hosts in hospitality

Strasbourg note: seat of the European Parliament and the Council of Europe, with strong institutional ties to EU solidarity programmes and proximity to Germany and Switzerland, giving volunteers exceptional intercultural exposure.

6. Financial model and all assumptions

The model is calibrated to Porto and identical to the interactive application. Other cities keep the Porto cost base and replace rent, nightly prices, wages and ESC unit costs with local figures.

6.1 Revenue and design assumptions

Assumption	Value	Status	Reasoning
ESC organisational support (A1)	€27/day (PT) ≈ €810/vol/month	**[Verified]**	Unit cost per day per participant by host country (ESC unit-cost decision v4.0, table 3.8; check the current Guide's table). Covers volunteer subsistence (lodging, meals, local travel) and support. Only line that offsets costs.
Pocket money (A3)	€6/day (PT) ≈ €180/vol/month	**[Verified]**	Paid to the volunteer weekly or monthly; pass-through, nets to zero.
Travel	€28–€1,735 per participant	**[Verified]**	Fixed amount by distance band; pass-through. Base case: 500–1,999 km band (€309, €417 green).
Excluded from base case	—	**[Design choice]**	Management cost (€238/participant, paid to the lead organisation), linguistic support (€150, only if OLS does not cover the language), inclusion support, exceptional costs.
Number of volunteers	4	**[Design choice]**	A1 of €3,240/month in Porto while manageable for one part-time manager; also allows one third-country volunteer above the 25% limit.
Scale	20 beds (16 dorm + 4 private)	**[Design choice]**	Below 15 beds revenue is insufficient at realistic occupancy; above 30 regulatory complexity rises. Dorms give volume and hostel character; privates give margin.
Dorm price (Porto)	€23/bed/night	**[Estimate]**	Hostelworld and Booking.com survey 2024–25; range €18–30. Conservative for a new hostel without reviews.
Private price (Porto)	€48/room/night	**[Estimate]**	Urban European private rooms 2024–25; range €35–65.
Days per month	30	**[Design choice]**	Simplification; use 365 days for precise annual figures.
Occupancy Year 1	45%	**[Estimate]**	New entrant with zero reviews; realistic 35–50% (Tuckman & Chang, 1991).
Occupancy Year 2	65%	**[Estimate]**	Review profile matures; 60–70% (Battilana & Lee, 2014).
Occupancy Year 3	80%	**[Estimate]**	Community differentiation fully visible; 75–85% (Ladhari, 2008).
Stress test	Year 1 without A1	**[Design choice]**	Tests a delayed or missing A1 payment at 45% occupancy. Exact break-even without A1 is 43.3% (€7,270 ÷ €16,800).
Activities income	€100 / €300 / €500	**[Estimate]**	Events and workshops, Years 1–3. Deliberately conservative; excluded from break-even.

6.2 Monthly cost structure (Porto)

Cost line	Monthly	Status	Reasoning
Property rental	€3,200	[Estimate]	Inner-city 150–200 m²; Idealista.pt / Imovirtual.pt 2024–25; range €2,800–3,500. Largest cost driver.
Utilities	€650	[Estimate]	Small commercial property; range €400–1,000.
Internet + PMS + channel manager	€180	[Estimate]	PMS €80–150 (Cloudbeds, Mews); channel manager €50–80 (SiteMinder, Beds24).
Civil liability insurance	€130	[Verified]	€75,000 minimum per claim, Portaria 248/2021; ≈ €1,560/year.
Volunteer meals	€900	[Estimate]	4 × €225. Host obligation (meals or food allowance, incl. holidays), funded from A1; no separate EU food allowance.
Volunteer local transport	€160	[Estimate]	4 × €40 monthly pass. Host must ensure local transport is available.
Skill workshops	€100	[Estimate]	Minimum one workshop a month for Quality Label compliance; €200–500 for a stronger programme.
Part-time manager (20h/week)	€760	[Estimate]	PT minimum wage 2026 €920 (DL 139/2025): €460 gross + 23.75% employer charges ≈ €570, plus payroll administration and occupational insurance.
Paid housekeeping (20h/week)	€570	[Estimate]	€460 gross + 23.75% employer charges at the PT 2026 minimum wage. Keeps routine cleaning with paid staff (no job substitution).
Cleaning supplies + consumables	€220	[Estimate]	Supplies only; rises with occupancy (€300–350 at 80%).
Marketing + digital tools	€200	[Estimate]	Heavier in Year 1; the first 20 reviews matter most.
Contingency	€200	[Estimate]	≈ 10% buffer on variable costs; €400 for older properties.
Total operating costs	**€7,270**	[Calculated]	**Sum of the above; €87,240 a year.**

6.3 City presets used by the calculator

City	A1 / A3 €/day	Rent	Dorm / private	Manager / housekeeping	Operating costs	Break-even with A1	Without A1
Porto [Verified]	27 / 6	€3,200	€23 / €48	€760 / €570	€7,270	24%	43.3%
Lyon [Estimate]	28 / 8	€2,600	€21 / €44	€900 / €900	€7,140	24.6%	46.5%
Strasbourg [Estimate]	28 / 8	€2,150	€19 / €40	€900 / €900	€6,690	23.9%	48.1%
Berlin [Estimate]	33 / 7	€3,000	€24 / €50	€1,109 / €1,109	€7,958	22.8%	45.4%
Barcelona [Estimate]	25 / 6	€3,300	€22 / €46	€593 / €593	€7,226	26.3%	44.9%
Rome [Estimate]	28 / 6	€2,700	€22 / €46	€900 / €900	€7,240	24.1%	45%

Rent is the midpoint of each city's range (Porto uses the model figure). Non-Porto private prices are estimated at about twice the dorm price. A1 and A3 are verified country rates. Non-Porto manager and housekeeping figures

are gross wage shares (no employer charges). Other lines reuse Porto values until local quotes are available.

6.4 Scenarios — Porto

Porto — monthly	Year 1 (45%)	Year 2 (65%)	Year 3 (80%)	Year 1, no A1 (45%)
Dorm revenue (16 × €23 × 30)	€4,968	€7,176	€8,832	€4,968
Private revenue (4 × €48 × 30)	€2,592	€3,744	€4,608	€2,592
ESC organisational support (A1: 4 × €27 × 30)	€3,240	€3,240	€3,240	€0
Activities and events	€100	€300	€500	€100
Operating revenue	**€10,900**	**€14,460**	**€17,180**	**€7,660**
Operating costs	€7,270	€7,270	€7,270	€7,270
Net monthly result	**€3,630**	**€7,190**	**€9,910**	**€390**
Net annual (× 12)	**€43,560**	**€86,280**	**€118,920**	**€4,680**
Pass-through: pocket money in (A3: 4 × €6 × 30)	€720	€720	€720	€720
Pass-through: pocket money paid out	−€720	−€720	−€720	−€720

Scenarios — Lyon

Lyon — monthly	Year 1 (45%)	Year 2 (65%)	Year 3 (80%)	Year 1, no A1 (45%)
Dorm revenue (16 × €21 × 30)	€4,536	€6,552	€8,064	€4,536
Private revenue (4 × €44 × 30)	€2,376	€3,432	€4,224	€2,376
ESC organisational support (A1: 4 × €28 × 30)	€3,360	€3,360	€3,360	€0
Activities and events	€100	€300	€500	€100
Operating revenue	**€10,372**	**€13,644**	**€16,148**	**€7,012**
Operating costs	€7,140	€7,140	€7,140	€7,140
Net monthly result	**€3,232**	**€6,504**	**€9,008**	**−€128**
Net annual (× 12)	**€38,784**	**€78,048**	**€108,096**	**−€1,536**
Pass-through: pocket money in (A3: 4 × €8 × 30)	€960	€960	€960	€960
Pass-through: pocket money paid out	−€960	−€960	−€960	−€960

Scenarios — Strasbourg

Strasbourg — monthly	Year 1 (45%)	Year 2 (65%)	Year 3 (80%)	Year 1, no A1 (45%)
Dorm revenue (16 × €19 × 30)	€4,104	€5,928	€7,296	€4,104
Private revenue (4 × €40 × 30)	€2,160	€3,120	€3,840	€2,160
ESC organisational support (A1: 4 × €28 × 30)	€3,360	€3,360	€3,360	€0
Activities and events	€100	€300	€500	€100
Operating revenue	**€9,724**	**€12,708**	**€14,996**	**€6,364**
Operating costs	€6,690	€6,690	€6,690	€6,690
Net monthly result	**€3,034**	**€6,018**	**€8,306**	**−€326**
Net annual (× 12)	**€36,408**	**€72,216**	**€99,672**	**−€3,912**
Pass-through: pocket money in (A3: 4 × €8 × 30)	€960	€960	€960	€960
Pass-through: pocket money paid out	−€960	−€960	−€960	−€960

Scenarios — Berlin

Berlin — monthly	Year 1 (45%)	Year 2 (65%)	Year 3 (80%)	Year 1, no A1 (45%)
Dorm revenue (16 × €24 × 30)	€5,184	€7,488	€9,216	€5,184
Private revenue (4 × €50 × 30)	€2,700	€3,900	€4,800	€2,700
ESC organisational support (A1: 4 × €33 × 30)	€3,960	€3,960	€3,960	€0
Activities and events	€100	€300	€500	€100
Operating revenue	**€11,944**	**€15,648**	**€18,476**	**€7,984**
Operating costs	€7,958	€7,958	€7,958	€7,958
Net monthly result	**€3,986**	**€7,690**	**€10,518**	**€26**
Net annual (× 12)	**€47,832**	**€92,280**	**€126,216**	**€312**
Pass-through: pocket money in (A3: 4 × €7 × 30)	€840	€840	€840	€840
Pass-through: pocket money paid out	−€840	−€840	−€840	−€840

Scenarios — Barcelona

Barcelona — monthly	Year 1 (45%)	Year 2 (65%)	Year 3 (80%)	Year 1, no A1 (45%)
Dorm revenue (16 × €22 × 30)	€4,752	€6,864	€8,448	€4,752
Private revenue (4 × €46 × 30)	€2,484	€3,588	€4,416	€2,484
ESC organisational support (A1: 4 × €25 × 30)	€3,000	€3,000	€3,000	€0
Activities and events	€100	€300	€500	€100
Operating revenue	**€10,336**	**€13,752**	**€16,364**	**€7,336**
Operating costs	€7,226	€7,226	€7,226	€7,226
Net monthly result	**€3,110**	**€6,526**	**€9,138**	**€110**
Net annual (× 12)	**€37,320**	**€78,312**	**€109,656**	**€1,320**
Pass-through: pocket money in (A3: 4 × €6 × 30)	€720	€720	€720	€720
Pass-through: pocket money paid out	−€720	−€720	−€720	−€720

Scenarios — Rome

Rome — monthly	Year 1 (45%)	Year 2 (65%)	Year 3 (80%)	Year 1, no A1 (45%)
Dorm revenue (16 × €22 × 30)	€4,752	€6,864	€8,448	€4,752
Private revenue (4 × €46 × 30)	€2,484	€3,588	€4,416	€2,484
ESC organisational support (A1: 4 × €28 × 30)	€3,360	€3,360	€3,360	€0
Activities and events	€100	€300	€500	€100
Operating revenue	**€10,696**	**€14,112**	**€16,724**	**€7,336**
Operating costs	€7,240	€7,240	€7,240	€7,240
Net monthly result	**€3,456**	**€6,872**	**€9,484**	**€96**
Net annual (× 12)	**€41,472**	**€82,464**	**€113,808**	**€1,152**
Pass-through: pocket money in (A3: 4 × €6 × 30)	€720	€720	€720	€720
Pass-through: pocket money paid out	−€720	−€720	−€720	−€720

6.5 Grant dependency (Porto)

Metric	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3
A1 as share of operating revenue	29.7%	22.4%	18.9%
Net margin with A1	33.3%	49.7%	57.7%
Break-even occupancy with A1	24%	—	—
Break-even occupancy without A1	43.3%	—	—

6.6 ESC account and the no-profit rule

The Guide states that beneficiaries must not derive any profit from the activities funded by the grant, and that organisations cover participants' costs without giving them salaries or an economic benefit. The model therefore separates two accounts: the **operating account** (beds, activities, A1 against all hostel costs) and an **ESC account** comparing A1 with the costs the volunteering activity actually generates. Hostel surplus comes from bed revenue, not from the grant, and is reinvested under the association's statutes.

Volunteer-related cost (Porto, monthly)	Allocation rule	Amount
Volunteer accommodation	20% of rent + utilities (€3,850)	€770
Meals or food allowance	4 × €225	€900
Local transport	4 × €40	€160
Skill workshops	100%	€100
Supervision and mentoring	50% of manager cost (€760)	€380
Total volunteer-related costs		**€2,310**
A1 received	**4 × €27 × 30**	**€3,240**
Coverage (A1 ÷ costs)		**140.3%**

Unit-cost grants are controlled on activities delivered rather than on receipts. In line with the no-profit rule, any difference between A1 and the allocated volunteer-related costs is reinvested in the volunteering programme: additional supervision hours, training materials and Youthpass support.

6.7 Travel: pass-through and sensitivity

Distance band (one way)	Standard	Green
10–99 km	€28	€56
100–499 km	€211	€285
500–1,999 km	€309	€417
2,000–2,999 km	€395	€535
3,000–3,999 km	€580	€785
4,000–7,999 km	€1,188	—
8,000 km or more	€1,735	—

Sensitivity (4 × 12-month placements)	Unit costs received	Ticket estimate	Gap
Base: 4 volunteers, 500–1,999 km (e.g. Paris, Madrid, Berlin–Porto)	€1,236	4 × €250 = €1,000	+€236
Far: 3 in EU band + 1 from 4,000–7,999 km (third country)	€2,115	3 × €250 + €700 = €1,450	+€665
Green: 4 volunteers, 500–1,999 km by train/bus	€1,668	4 × €350 = €1,400	+€268

Ticket prices are illustrative estimates; replace them with real quotes. Travel is shown as equal income and expense; any gap is volunteer travel support, not hostel revenue. Projects of four volunteers or fewer may include one third-country volunteer above the 25% limit, so the far-band case is realistic at most once per cohort.

6.8 Start-up investment (Porto)

Item	Estimate	Status	Note
Property deposit (3 months)	€9,600	**[Estimate]**	3 × €3,200; negotiable.
First month rent advance	€3,200	**[Estimate]**	Often required with the deposit in Portugal.
Renovation and fit-out	€20,000	**[Estimate]**	Range €15,000–25,000; get 3+ fixed-price quotes.
Furniture and equipment	€10,000	**[Estimate]**	Beds, lockers, kitchen, common areas; €8,000–12,000.
IT, access control, CCTV, Wi-Fi	€3,000	**[Estimate]**	Install during renovation.
Sustainability set-up	€800	**[Estimate]**	LED lighting, 5-stream recycling; needed for Green Key.
Legal, notary, registration	€2,500	**[Estimate]**	Statutes, RNPC, notary.
ESC Quality Label application	€0	**[Verified]**	Free — do not pay anyone to apply.
Alojamento Local registration	€300	**[Verify locally]**	Check current fee with Câmara Municipal.
Civil liability insurance, Year 1	€1,560	**[Verified]**	€130 × 12.
6-month operating reserve	€43,620	**[Estimate]**	6 × €7,270 operating costs. Covers ramp-up and delays in A1 payment.
Total start-up investment	**€94,580**	**[Calculated]**	**Sum of the above.**

7. Legal reference and portals

The ESC is established by Regulation (EU) 2021/888 of 20 May 2021. Operational rules — hours, support conditions, unit costs — sit in the annual ESC Guide, which is part of each call for proposals.

Rule	Source	Status	Content	Consequence for the toolkit
Objectives	Reg. 2021/888, Art. 3	**[Verified]**	General and specific objectives: solidarity, cohesion, young people's engagement in quality solidarity activities.	Phases 1–2: cite in mission and statutes.
Volunteering	Reg. 2021/888, Art. 7	**[Verified]**	Includes a learning and training component; must not substitute traineeships or jobs; not equated with employment; written volunteering agreement.	Phase 5: competency first. Substitution puts the Quality Label at risk.
Eligibility	Reg. 2021/888	**[Verified]**	Registration from 17; aged 18–30 at the start of volunteering.	Phase 7: check age on the start date.
Working time	ESC Guide	**[Verify locally]**	Full-time volunteering of about 30–38 hours a week; weekly days off and monthly leave.	Phase 5: rotas and role descriptions.
Host tasks	ESC Guide 2026	**[Verified]**	Suitable accommodation and healthy meals (or food allowance), incl. holidays; local transport available; due allowance weekly or monthly; mentor; task support.	Phase 8; costed in the model.
Quality Label	ESC Guide; European Youth Portal	**[Verified]**	Non-budgetary award; prerequisite to take part. Host, support, lead roles; continuous submission. Only lead organisations apply for funding; lead label needs one year of legal establishment.	Phase 4; lead label in Years 2–3.
Travel	ESC Guide	**[Verify locally]**	Unit cost by distance band (EU distance calculator); extra support for green travel.	Phase 7.
Unit costs	Unit-cost decision v4.0; ESC Guide	**[Verified]**	A1 per day (PT €27, FR €28, DE €33, ES €25, IT €28); A3 per day (PT €6, FR €8, DE €7, ES €6, IT €6); travel €28–€1,735 by band; management €238/participant; linguistic €150.	Only A1 offsets costs; A3 and travel are pass-throughs.
No profit	ESC Guide 2026; EU Financial Regulation	**[Verified]**	No profit from grant-funded activities; cover participants' costs, no salaries or economic benefit.	Separate ESC account; surplus from beds reinvested.
No job substitution	ESC Guide 2026, Quality Label principles	**[Verified]**	Volunteers complement paid staff; must not replace them or undercut pay and conditions; avoid routine low-learning tasks.	Paid housekeeping; supervised learning roles.

7.1 EU-level portals and documents

Resource	Address	Use
Regulation (EU) 2021/888	eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=CELEX:32021R0888	Legal basis
ESC Guide and reference documents	youth.europa.eu/solidarity/organisations/reference-documents-resources_en	Current Guide, unit-cost annexes, expert guide
Quality Label	youth.europa.eu/solidarity/organisations/quality-label_en	Accreditation
Calls for proposals and forms	youth.europa.eu/solidarity/organisations/calls-for-proposals_en	ESC50 (Quality Label), ESC51 (project)
EU Login	webgate.ec.europa.eu/cas	Account for OID and applications
Organisation registration (OID)	webgate.ec.europa.eu/erasmus-esc/index/	Obtain OID
Youthpass	youthpass.eu	Key competences, certificate
Online Language Support	erasmusplusols.eu (may redirect to EU Academy)	Language learning
Green Key	greenkey.global	Eco-label, Year 2

7.2 National entry points

Country	ESC agency	Association registration	Tourist accommodation
Portugal	Agência Nacional Erasmus+ Juventude/Desporto e CES; IPDJ (ipdj.gov.pt)	rnpc.mj.pt	balcaodoempreendedor.gov.pt
France	erasmusplus-jeunesse.fr	service-public.fr/associations (Alsace-Moselle: Tribunal judiciaire)	Mairie; service-public.fr
Germany	jugendfuereuropa.de	Amtsgericht Vereinsregister	service.berlin.de (Gewerbeamt)
Spain	injuve.es	Registre d'Entitats Jurídiques (justicia.gencat.cat)	empresa.gencat.cat; Ajuntament (PEUAT)
Italy	agenziagioventu.gov.it	RUNTS (servizi.lavoro.gov.it/runts)	SUAP; comune.roma.it

8. Data sources

Every figure in the toolkit is traceable to a named source. Porto figures are verified against primary sources; figures for the other five cities are orientation estimates that require local verification.

8.1 Programme and regulatory sources

Figure or rule	Value	Source
ESC legal basis, objectives, volunteering	Arts. 3 and 7	Regulation (EU) 2021/888
Quality Label, host tasks, no profit, no job substitution	—	European Solidarity Corps Guide 2026, Part B
Organisational support (A1)	PT €27, FR €28, DE €33, ES €25, IT €28 per day	Commission decision on ESC unit contributions, table 3.8
Pocket money (A3)	PT €6, FR €8, DE €7, ES €6, IT €6 per day	Commission decision on ESC unit contributions, table 3.8
Travel	€28–€1,735 per participant by band	ESC Guide 2026; unit-cost decision, table 1
Management / linguistic support	€238 / €150 per participant	Unit-cost decision, section 3.8
Participant age	18–30 at start; registration from 17	ESC Guide 2026, Part A

8.2 Portugal (verified case)

Figure or rule	Value	Source
Civil liability insurance minimum	€75,000 per claim	Portaria 248/2021
Minimum wage 2026	€920/month gross	Decreto-Lei 139/2025
Alojamento Local; condominium approval	AL registration; written assembly approval	DL 128/2014 as amended by DL 76/2024
Association legal form	Associação	Código Civil, Arts. 167–184; RNPC
Tourist tax	€2/person/night, max 7 nights	Câmara Municipal do Porto
Precedent	Associação Spin, OID E10339100	a-spin.pt
Rent, prices	€3,200; €23 dorm, €48 private	Idealista.pt, Imovirtual.pt, Hostelworld, Booking.com (market estimates)

8.3 Academic grounding of occupancy assumptions

Assumption	Value	Reference
Year 1 occupancy (new entrant)	45%	Tuckman & Chang (1991)
Year 2 occupancy (reputation maturing)	65%	Battilana & Lee (2014)
Year 3 occupancy (mature community hostel)	80%	Ladhari (2008)
Toolkit as a method artefact	—	Hevner et al. (2004)

9. Limitations and disclaimer

- No primary interviews were conducted with ESC host practitioners, national agency officers or regulators; the toolkit relies on documentary evidence and the Associação Spin precedent.
- Financial figures rest on market data current at the time of research and must be validated against live local data before any commitment.
- Five of the six cities are orientation points; practitioners there must confirm every regulatory detail themselves.
- ESC rules and unit costs change with each annual call; the ESC Guide for the current year prevails over this document.
- As Pandza and Thorpe (2010) note, management design artefacts operate under social complexity that no specification fully anticipates; real implementations will meet challenges this framework cannot predict.

Disclaimer

This document and the interactive application are prototype outputs of an M2 thesis at KEDGE Business School. They are not financial, legal or tax advice. Verify every figure and rule with the relevant national ESC agency, local authorities and professional advisers before acting.